

The Coherent Inheritance Framework (CIF)

A cross-domain framework for how systems inherit structure, preserve coherence, drift, recover, and transmit forward.

Author: Derek Hone · Remnant Fieldworks Inc.

Series: CIF Ancient Systems Test Series

Status and Evidence Discipline

The Coherent Inheritance Framework (CIF) is a **candidate conceptual and systems framework**, not established physics and not a proven universal theory. It is offered as a structured vocabulary and a set of design propositions for reasoning about how systems persist, degrade, and pass structure forward across time.

CIF was originally developed under the working title **Unified Inheritance Physics (UIP)**. The “Unified” designation was retired after a preregistered universality claim failed to survive testing. The renaming to Coherent Inheritance Framework is deliberate: it is a more accurate and more evidence-disciplined description of what the framework actually claims. This provenance is stated plainly rather than concealed, because honest inheritance of one’s own intellectual history is itself a CIF commitment.

Throughout this framework and every case study in the series, claims are separated into what is **established**, what is **plausible inference**, and what is **speculative**. Contested claims are flagged explicitly, the mainstream scholarly position is presented first, and alternatives are labeled as such. No statistics are invented; where a quantitative claim cannot be sourced, a qualitative status is given instead.

CIF’s governing question is not merely “what is this system?” but:

What does this system inherit, what field does it operate within, what keeps it coherent, what causes it to drift, what can be restored, and what will it transmit next?

Central Proposition

CIF begins from a single observation: **no durable system exists in complete isolation**. Every enduring system inherits conditions, structure, information, energy, authority, constraints, or value; operates within an environment or field; must preserve enough internal coherence to keep functioning; experiences drift, noise, decay, or corruption; transforms what it receives; and passes forward either improved inheritance, degraded inheritance, or nothing at all.

The central CIF proposition is:

A system survives when it can preserve coherent inheritance through change without crossing the boundary of harm.

The framework is organized around six recurring concepts — **fields, resonance, coherence, drift, inheritance, and stewardship** — formalized into six axioms and two complementary five-part lenses: the **Five Engineering Pillars** (a prospective method for governing a live system) and the **Five Inheritance Layers** (a retrospective diagnostic for what a system preserved or lost across time).

The Six Axioms

Under CIF these are treated as **design propositions**, not universal physical laws.

Axiom 1 — Systems operate within structured fields.

No system is entirely independent of its environment, inputs, constraints, or relationships. A “field” in CIF is the structured environment of relationships, constraints, timing, and flows within which a system operates. This is deliberately broader than the physical-science meaning: a field may be electrical, computational, biological, organizational, economic, legal, informational, or a network of human relationships. CIF does not claim these fields are physically identical; field is used as a cross-domain systems abstraction.

Axiom 2 — Productive transfer depends on appropriate matching.

Energy, information, authority, or intervention must match the relevant state and boundary conditions of the receiving system. The right intervention delivered at the wrong time, scale, state, or boundary may fail or cause harm. CIF therefore favors matched intervention over brute force.

Axiom 3 — Drift and noise may contain recoverable inheritance.

Errors, losses, waste, and failures should be examined for useful energy, information, diagnostics, or learning before being discarded. This does not imply all waste is recoverable or harmless; some outputs must be isolated or destroyed. The principle is: before discarding an output, determine whether it contains recoverable energy, information, material, evidence, or learning.

Axiom 4 — Coherence is the condition of stable operation.

A system must preserve sufficient internal and external alignment to continue functioning under change. Coherence is not perfection, stillness, or uniformity — a coherent system may be dynamic, adaptive, distributed, and noisy. It remains coherent when its variation is organized rather than destructive. Coherence is organized continuity under change.

Axiom 5 — Safe operation must be bounded.

A system should not be allowed to pursue performance without enforceable limits. Safety is not merely a feature; it is a boundary, a covenant, and a hard constraint.

Axiom 6 — Trunks generate forests.

A foundational mechanism may support many implementations across different domains. A durable “trunk” — a core design pattern — can seed a “forest” of downstream systems.

The Five Engineering Pillars

The pillars translate CIF from worldview into method.

Pillar 1 — Sense the field. Observe the actual state before intervening: load, timing, noise, authority, evidence, risk, resource availability, environmental conditions. Core rule: do not govern a system you have not observed.

Pillar 2 — Match the response. Choose an intervention appropriate to the measured state. Avoid fixed responses when the system requires contextual control.

Pillar 3 — Adapt under change. Continue measuring and adjust within permitted limits. Do not assume yesterday's valid state remains valid now. Distinguish bounded adaptation from open-ended optimization.

Pillar 4 — Recirculate recoverable waste. Capture useful output, failure information, excess energy, rejected states, or lessons and return them safely into the system — bounded, measurable, state-aware, reversible where possible, and prevented from amplifying harmful signals.

Pillar 5 — Enforce non-harm coherence. Maintain hard boundaries against uses that cause disproportionate harm. Warnings must be designed so they remain warnings after context is lost. Stewardship is the moral and operational center: the operator is temporarily responsible for inherited power, information, resources, people, and consequences.

The Five Inheritance Layers

The Engineering Pillars above describe how an operator should govern a live system. When the question is instead **what survives across discontinuity** — which is the central question of every case study in this series — CIF uses a second, complementary five-part lens: the **Inheritance Layers**. These name the distinct things that can be preserved or lost independently of one another.

Layer 1 — Physical form. The material substrate carrying the inheritance (stone, clay, wood, bronze, or — in the oral case — the human body and relationships). Can survive by design, by accident, or not at all.

Layer 2 — Data. The recoverable signal encoded in the substrate: the marks, ratios, glyphs, or measurements. Data can survive intact even when nothing else does.

Layer 3 — Method. The reproducible procedure that regenerates capability — how to build, run, or perform the thing, not merely a record that it existed.

Layer 4 — Intent. The purpose and meaning the signal was meant to carry: why it was made, what it was for.

Layer 5 — Semantic continuity. Whether a future receiver can understand, not merely read — the survival of the reader, the language, and the cultural/technical context that makes the data meaningful. This is the layer most often severed while Layers 1-2 remain perfectly intact.

Why two five-part schemes. The Engineering Pillars are a prospective governance method (how to steward a system now); the Inheritance Layers are a retrospective fidelity diagnostic (what a system preserved or lost across time). They are distinct tools and must not be conflated: “Pillar 3” under the Engineering lens means adapt under change, while “Layer 3” under the Inheritance lens means method. Case studies state which lens they are applying (see the canonical structure below).

The Canonical Case-Study Structure

Every case study in the CIF Ancient Systems Test Series follows this exact structure, established by Case Study #1 (The Giza Transmission Hypothesis):

1. **Status** — speculative / disciplined framing
2. **Core Question**
3. **Evidence Discipline**
4. **Three Evidence Classes** — ESTABLISHED / PLAUSIBLE INFERENCE / SPECULATIVE
5. **CIF Axiom Analysis** — all six axioms
6. **CIF Pillar Analysis** — all five of whichever lens fits the case. Phase-1 studies (01 Giza, 02 Aboriginal Oral Traditions, 05 Tsunami Stones) apply the **Five Engineering Pillars** (Sense / Match / Adapt / Recirculate / Enforce non-harm). Phase-2 studies (03 Antikythera, 04 Bronze Age Collapse, 06 Polynesian Wayfinding, 07 Göbekli Tepe, 08 Undeciphered Scripts) apply the **Five Inheritance Layers** (Physical form / Data / Method / Intent / Semantic continuity), because the governing question in those cases is what survived across discontinuity rather than how to govern a live system. Each study states which lens it uses.
7. **Fidelity Assessment** — qualitative status per **Inheritance Layer** (physical form, data, method, intent, semantic meaning, error log); no invented percentages
8. **Implications for the Present**
9. **Design Requirements / Lessons Derived**
10. **Conclusions** — numbered
11. **Final CIF Verdict**

In addition, every case study in this series includes a **Falsification Check** — an explicit statement of what finding would contradict CIF, and whether the evidence approaches that finding. The series is deliberately constructed to include genuine potential counterexamples. These are not confirmation-only analyses; a framework that cannot be challenged by evidence is not a framework worth trusting.

Why Ancient Systems

Ancient systems are natural CIF test benches because they have already run the full experiment that modern systems have not yet finished: they inherited structure, operated within a field, drifted, and either transmitted forward or failed. The archaeological and historical record is, in effect, a completed dataset of inheritance outcomes across civilizational timescales. By stress-testing CIF's propositions against these cases — including cases that appear to contradict earlier CIF conclusions — the framework can be supported, refined, or challenged on evidence rather than on assertion.